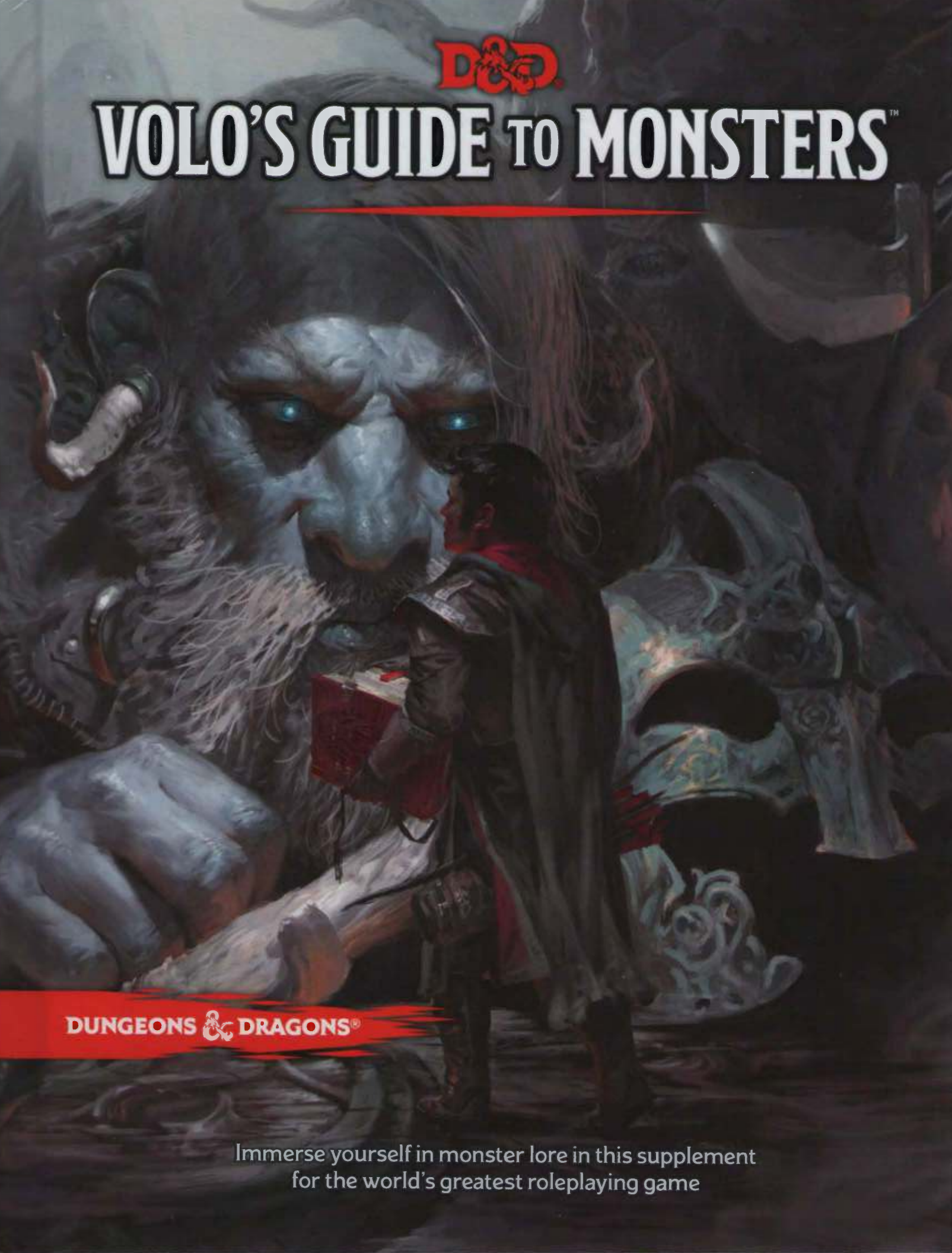

D&D
VOLO'S GUIDE TO MONSTERS™
DUNGEONS & DRAGONS®
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VOLO'S GUIDE TO MONSTERS™



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About This Book

Monsters are the heart of this book—where they live, how they think, how they might befriend you, and how they might harm you. Chapter 1 delves into the stories of some of the monstrous groups presented in the *Monster Manual*. Chapter 2 supplements the race options in the *Player's Handbook*, and chapter 3 introduces a host of monsters and their stat blocks. Appendix A provides a few new beasts, and appendix B is stocked with non-player characters to populate your D&D adventures. Appendix C lets you look up stat blocks in this book by challenge rating, creature type, and environment.

Sprinkled throughout the book are observations and musings from two denizens of the Forgotten Realms: the legendary explorer Volothamp Geddarm (Volo to his friends) and the Archmage of Shadowdale himself, Elminster Aumar. For the benefit of DMs and players everywhere, Volo and Elminster share their insights with regard to some of the monsters found herein, and their words hold a measure of truth regardless of the D&D world in which these monsters are met.

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ON THE COVER

Tyler Jacobson illustrates a fateful meeting between a suspicious frost giant and a lone adventurer armed with *Volo's Guide to Monsters*. Will the giant cleave our learned hero in two, or will diplomacy win the day?

Disclaimer: Wizards of the Coast does not vouch for, guarantee, or provide any promise regarding the validity of the information provided in this volume by Volothamp Geddarm. Do not trust Volo. Do not go on quests offered by Volo. Do not listen to Volo. Avoid being seen with him for risk of guilt by association. If Volo appears in your campaign, your DM is undoubtedly trying to kill your character in o manner that can be blamed on your own actions. The DM is probably trying to do that anyway, but with Volo's appearance, you know for sure. We're not convinced that Elminster's commentary is all that trustworthy either, but he turned us into flumphs the last time we mentioned him in one of these disclaimers.

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Preface

Well met, adventurer. You seem like a curious sort who enjoys the finer things. Permit me to thrust upon you my latest masterwork, years in the making. I think you'll find it well worth your time and money. First, a warning: here there be monsters!

No less a peerless font of sagacity as Elminster of Shadowdale[1] has attested that more worlds than this one teem with monsters. As a result, that "Here there be monsters" line has appeared on maps of worlds far from this one, and hidden from your modest[2] scribe. And who am I, you ask?

Volothamp Geddarm at your service, setting forth truths like the deep and ancient secrets whispered into my ears by the guardian spirits of the hidden tombs of fallen archmages now dust. Yes, in this very tome, I set forth divers details, never before gathered with such coherence[3] in one place, of the creatures varied and strange that it pleases humans and most other civilized races to deem "monsters."

I cannot recommend the essential lore contained in this volume highly enough,[4] and cry it to be "life-savingly necessary" to every adventurer and wayfarer in the wilderlands and the Underdark, be they prospector, miner, or merely seeking shelter in a cavern from prowling beasts or the claws of winter, over the world entire.[5] And should you find it within yourself to complain that this or that entry is lacking in veracity or comprehensive completeness,[6] let it be known that I, Volo, took no shortcuts, and stinted not in the depth of my probings[7] or the courting of discomforts in gathering the most extensive and authoritative lore possible. At great personal risk, might I add![8]

Betimes I used my not-inconsiderable[9] magic to disguise myself as a tree, stone, or even a puddle, and so prepare the very best guide I possibly could. In the doing, I have seen the most wondrous vistas, from frosty high mountain peaks where giant castles drift past, to the deepest icy lakes beneath the earth, where nameless tentacled things stir and slither, and was awed anew at the beauty of the world that we all, monstrous or otherwise, share.[10]

If you find this tome of use, please tell your friends, business partners, and acquaintances met in passing in the street. Then perhaps I'll have the chance to pen an even more useful guide, in future.[11] And whatever befalls you or me in our unfolding lives, I remain your humble scribe and obedient servant, and am now (and if the gods grant, forever in lasting fame),

Volothamp Geddarm[12]



Notes from Elminster Aumar, Archmage of Shadowdale, Senior Advisor to the Open Lord of Waterdeep:

1. Lay it on thick, will ye?
2. If this is modest, I dare not think what preening be.
3. Coherence, indeed.! Volo, thy clarity is as the churning surface of a large city cesspit—when tentacles are about to erupt from beneath.!
4. The modesty is blinding.! Such a paragon of elucidation, selflessly serving all. Often on a platter, with an apple in every mouth.
5. Earplugs sold separately.
6. Here it comes. Get in first.! Head off thy legitimate critics.
7. The sanity of those who babble of probes is seldom held in high regard.
8. Ye may, though ye're obviously unaware, young Volo, how often and for how long I have been telling dragons, mind flayers, and even goblins how truly vile Volothamps taste, raw or cooked. Ye're welcome.
9. Betimes Volo misconstrues the meaning of words. Here, for example, he means, "nonexistent."
10. Until we kill each other, using Volo's handy tips, bundled up neatly herein.
11. VOLO'S GUIDE TO FLEEING ANGRY MOBS. I foresee a short work, but a classic.
12. Let me be fair. The lad means well and has done well. Better than I expected. Some of what's in this book is true, and can even be trusted.